

Vince Herr Initial 1 on 1

Situation 1: Starting With a New Team

When a manager joins a team, the first round of 1:1 meetings should be treated as discovery conversations. The goal is to understand how the team actually operates, what is working well and where problems exist.

These conversations help reveal the difference between the official process and the real one.

Understanding the Team

- What part of the team's work do you think is going especially well right now?
- If you could change one thing about how the team operates, what would it be?
- What part of our workflow feels harder than it should be?

Execution and Process

- Where do workstreams usually slow down?
- What tends to surprise us during projects?
- What types of work cause the most interruptions?

Leadership Expectations

- What do you think this team needs most from a manager?
- What did your previous manager do that worked well?
- What did you wish they had done differently?

Hidden Problems

- What issue do people complain about privately but not in meetings?
- What causes the most frustration on the team today?

These questions help the manager understand the real operating environment of the team.

Notes

- The Good
 - Eng / Company culture in Member locator was really good

- Pipelines now has most of that
 - Kit is one of those individuals
 - That was earned and built overtime with that context
- A lot of things changed based on leadership changes
 - Comp changes
 - Leadership changes
 - Equity changes
- The people who are still here have seen the old culture go away
- New people tend to just do what they are asked and do the work
- 2 different engineering cultures in this current environment
- Creates a point of friction
- Alignment around timelines and urgency
 - Especially with our team
 - He holds a ton of the knowledge
 - Threading the needle with how to share his time in a constructive way while hitting the deadlines
 - Onboarding feels like a net neutral which doesn't help with productivity
 - Claude is changing some of that right now, but still produces wonky results
 - Ability to judge quality quickly
- Product and Engineering
 - Connor has been here since December
 - Knows virtually nothing about the new product
 - When he has the space and info he makes strong decisions, but is continually playing catch up
 - Creates a really weird situation where they are trying to protect eng time, but creates gaps
 - Good intentions, but doesn't empower engineers to make good decisions
 - Example is combining support tickets which doesn't allow root cause analysis
 - Team has not adapted well to the support. The scripts have not been working as expected. Need to revisit
- AI slop
 - Sees like product is using it a lot and not really having the understanding
 - The output isn't as quality as it should be.
- Spoke up after frustration
 - Direct vs Kind
 - Wants to give people space to onboard and doesn't want to just tell people what to do
 - Likes to work from a position of built understanding
 - Too much to do so had to speak up to make sure they get up to pace
 - He isn't formally the manager of the team and isn't in the room for a lot of roadmap planning, etc.
 - Hasn't been going that well

- Process is going to help, but this timeline is not the same as this current urgent timeline.
- Hit short term and create a healthy team
- Needs to be more direct with people right now
- Right now making him feel like he is just making people do the work the way he would do.
- Kitt and Kevin seems to be able to do the work
- Magaly has been difficult to get on board and needs a lot of hand holding
 - Seems like she is using a lot of AI, but the output is not great.
 - May cause a lot of issues in a crunch situation
 - Support is probably the hardest part of it because of how all the systems align
 - Really needs to audit data and understand the lay of the land
 - Not asking a lot of the right questions
- We may not be able to do this with the current resources
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- Team
- Zone wide
- Product
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Kevin is going to vest and be out after